converted into basic elements again. Their impacts do not remain localized. GHGs prevent the escape of heat into the outer atmosphere. They act like traps and contribute to heating up the planet; the eventual consequence is ‘global warming’, which, as the name suggests, affects the entire world. Likewise, chemical substances used in air-conditioners and other cooling devices can cut into the ozone layer and deplete it. This again has a global impact as the ozone layer acts as a shield to prevent harmful rays coming in from outer space.

Global Response to Environmental Deterioration Has Evolved since the 1960s

There were episodes of severe environmental distress in the world before global awareness developed to treat environmental deterioration as a serious threat to mankind. The notorious London smog caused by burning of coal and acid rains in some parts of the US and Europe caused not just severe discomfort and health issues but also fatalities. However, these episodes were treated as local and the rest of the world was not unduly concerned or alarmed.

Rachel Carson’s book *Silent Spring* (1962) is credited with bringing the adverse effects of uncontrolled chemical discharges in water streams to global consciousness. The impact of use of fossil fuels, discharge of chemicals and other industrial pollutants in water and air, and expanded production of non-biodegradable products began to assume serious proportions in the 1960s. The atmospheric discharge of GHGs also assumed a significant scale by then. This was the tipping decade when mankind began to understand the impact of development on the well-being of people and the environment.

Legislations for controlling environmental pollution started appearing in the 1960s. The US passed the Clean Air Act in 1963 to control air pollution; it adopted a comprehensive Clean Water Act in 1972. The Basic Law on